

Going Home with Patellar Luxation

A guide for your pet's recovery at home

Your pet was found to have a luxating patella (kneecap) while in our care at the shelter. This handout explains what to expect and how to care for your pet at home. Refer to your adoption paperwork for the specific grade and any treatment already performed.

What to Expect

- Patellar luxation is a condition where the kneecap (patella) slips out of its normal groove, causing intermittent skipping, hopping, or lameness in the leg.
- It is graded 1–4 based on severity — mild cases may be managed without surgery, while more significant cases often benefit from surgical correction.
- Refer to your adoption paperwork to see whether your pet's patella was surgically corrected or is being monitored.

Home Care

- If surgery was performed, restrict activity strictly — no running, jumping, or stairs — until cleared by your veterinarian.
- Give all pain medications exactly as directed, and keep the e-collar on if one was sent home to prevent licking at the incision.
- Keep your pet at a healthy weight — extra weight puts added strain on the joint and can worsen symptoms.
- Short, controlled leash walks are usually fine even without surgery; avoid rough play, jumping on/off furniture, and slick floors.

Contact Your Veterinarian If Your Pet Has:

- Increasing lameness or reluctance to put weight on the leg
- Swelling, redness, or discharge at a surgical site, if applicable
- Signs of pain despite medication
- The leg held up completely or appearing to “lock” in place
- Sudden worsening after the leg had been improving

Follow-Up Care

Schedule a follow-up visit with your veterinarian within **1–2 weeks** after adoption (or **10–14 days** if surgery was performed) to assess healing and progress.

Bring your adoption paperwork so your veterinarian knows the grade and any treatment already performed.

This handout provides general information and is not a substitute for veterinary care.